Important Questions with Answers

Chapter 5: State and Society up to 1000 CE
Class 9 Social Science (NCERT) - Understanding Society: India and Beyond, Part 1

A. MCQs B. Fill in the Blanks C. True/False D. Match the Following E. Assertion-Reason F. Short Answer G. Long Answer

A. Multiple Choice Questions (1 mark each)

Q1. The earliest literary source for the study of early Indian society is the:

(a) Arthashastra
(b) Rigveda
(c) Mahabharata
(d) Sangam literature

Answer: (b) Rigveda

Q2. A society is mainly regulated by:

(a) Formal laws only
(b) Customs and practices
(c) Armies
(d) Taxes

Answer: (b) Customs and practices (rather than formal laws)

Q3. The Rigveda consists of how many hymns (suktas)?

(a) 108
(b) 1,028
(c) 10,000
(d) 64

Answer: (b) 1,028

Q4. Which Veda forms the foundation of the system of seven svaras (notes) of Indian music?

(a) Rigveda
(b) Yajurveda
(c) Samaveda
(d) Atharvaveda

Answer: (c) Samaveda

Q5. The Upanishads deal mainly with issues like:

(a) Ritual instructions
(b) The Self (Atman) and the Ultimate Universal Being (Brahman)
(c) Taxation
(d) Medicine only

Answer: (b) The Self (Atman) and the Ultimate Universal Being (Brahman)

Q6. The five important janas of the Rigveda, collectively called the panchajana, include:

(a) Yadu, Turvasha, Puru, Anu and Druhyu
(b) Kuru, Panchala, Matsya, Kosala and Kashi
(c) Chera, Chola, Pandya, Maurya and Gupta
(d) Anga, Vanga, Kalinga, Magadha and Avanti

Answer: (a) Yadu, Turvasha, Puru, Anu and Druhyu

Q7. Which of the following was NOT an assembly of the Vedic period?

(a) Sabha
(b) Samiti
(c) Vidhata
(d) Sangha

Answer: (d) Sangha (the three Vedic assemblies were sabha, samiti and vidhata)

Q8. The term 'janapada' literally means:

(a) A fort
(b) Where a people (jana) first set its feet
(c) A royal court
(d) A village council

Answer: (b) Where a people (jana) first set its feet

Q9. How many mahajanapadas are usually mentioned in historical sources?

(a) Four
(b) Eight
(c) Sixteen
(d) Thirty

Answer: (c) Sixteen

Q10. Which mahajanapada gradually became the most powerful?

(a) Kosala
(b) Avanti
(c) Magadha
(d) Gandhara

Answer: (c) Magadha (present-day Bihar)

Q11. The Mauryan Empire was founded by Chandragupta Maurya in:

(a) 600 BCE
(b) 321 BCE
(c) 185 BCE
(d) 320 CE

Answer: (b) 321 BCE

Q12. In the Deccan, the Mauryan Empire was succeeded by the:

(a) Kushanas
(b) Satavahanas
(c) Pallavas
(d) Palas

Answer: (b) Satavahanas (2nd century BCE to 3rd century CE)

Q13. The emblem of the Cholas was the:

(a) Bow
(b) Fish
(c) Tiger
(d) Elephant

Answer: (c) Tiger (the bow for the Cheras and the fish for the Pandyas)

Q14. Sangam literature belongs to the period:

(a) 300 BCE to 300 CE
(b) 600 to 900 CE
(c) 1500 to 1000 BCE
(d) 800 to 1000 CE

Answer: (a) 300 BCE to 300 CE

Q15. According to the Arthashastra, 'prithivi' means:

(a) A river
(b) The area between the Himavat and the sea
(c) A city
(d) A village

Answer: (b) The area between the Himavat (Himalayas) and the sea

Q16. Kautilya's Saptanga refers to:

(a) Seven rivers
(b) Seven constituents of the state
(c) Seven vedas
(d) Seven ministers

Answer: (b) Seven constituents of the state

Q17. The Junagadh Rock Inscription bears records of which three rulers?

(a) Ashoka, Rudradaman I and Skandagupta
(b) Chandragupta, Harsha and Rajaraja
(c) Kharavela, Kanishka and Samudragupta
(d) Ashoka, Harsha and Pulakeshin

Answer: (a) Ashoka, Rudradaman I and Skandagupta

Q18. The new officer 'sandhivigrahika' introduced in the Gupta period was the:

(a) Treasurer
(b) Minister of peace and war
(c) Village head
(d) Chief tax collector

Answer: (b) Minister of peace and war

Q19. Tax-free land grants to villages by the Pallavas were called:

(a) Agraharams
(b) Brahmadeya villages
(c) Variyams
(d) Nadus

Answer: (b) Brahmadeya villages (the Chalukyas gave agraharams)

Q20. The 'Kudavolai' (ballot pot) system is described in the:

(a) Junagadh inscription
(b) Uttaramerur inscription
(c) Nashik inscription
(d) Mandsaur inscription

Answer: (b) Uttaramerur inscription of Parantaka I (10th century)

Q21. Which concept is described in the Rigveda as the all-pervading cosmic order?

(a) Samatva
(b) Rita
(c) Artha
(d) Kama

Answer: (b) Rita

Q22. The earliest reference to the four varnas appears in the:

(a) Purushasukta of the Rigveda
(b) Arthashastra
(c) Manusmriti
(d) Sutta Nipata

Answer: (a) Purushasukta, Book 10 of the Rigveda

Q23. Which of these is NOT one of the four purusharthas?

(a) Dharma
(b) Artha
(c) Karma
(d) Moksha

Answer: (c) Karma (the four are dharma, artha, kama and moksha)

Q24. The Alvars were saint-poets who composed hymns in praise of:

(a) Shiva
(b) Vishnu
(c) Shakti
(d) Surya

Answer: (b) Vishnu (the 63 Nayanmars praised Shiva)

Q25. The basic tax on land in the Mauryan state was generally:

(a) One-half of the produce
(b) One-sixth of the produce
(c) One-tenth of the produce
(d) One-third of the produce

Answer: (b) One-sixth of the produce

Q26. Which two major land trade routes had emerged by the 6th century BCE?

(a) Silk Route and Spice Route
(b) Dakshinapatha and Uttarapatha
(c) Grand Trunk and Coastal Route
(d) Royal Road and Kings Highway

Answer: (b) Dakshinapatha and Uttarapatha

Q27. Guilds were known as:

(a) Shrenis
(b) Sabhas
(c) Gramas
(d) Mandalas

Answer: (a) Shrenis

B. Fill in the Blanks (1 mark each)

Q28. The earliest sections of the Rigveda were composed in the region known as _____.

Answer: Sapta-Sindhu

Q29. Each Veda has four parts: samhita, brahmana, aranyaka and _____.

Answer: upanishad

Q30. In early Vedic society, the rajan functioned primarily as a _____ chief.

Answer: clan

Q31. The three assemblies of the Vedic period were sabha, samiti and _____.

Answer: vidhata

Q32. Northern India had monarchical states called _____ and republican states called ganas or sanghas.

Answer: rajyas

Q33. The Sangam age Chera king _____ extended his conquests up to the Himalayas.

Answer: Nedunjeral Adan

Q34. The Chola ruler Rajendra I adopted the title _____ to commemorate his conquest of regions along the Ganga.

Answer: Gangaikonda

Q35. Ashoka's edicts promoted _____, the moral way of life.

Answer: dhamma

Q36. The Damodarpur copper plates belong to the reign of _____ I.

Answer: Kumaragupta

Q37. Provinces were called _____ in the north and mandalas in the south in the period 300-800 CE.

Answer: bhuktis

Q38. The lowest administrative unit in the Chola empire was the _____ (individual village).

Answer: Ur

Q39. The village assemblies had small committees known as _____ for tasks like irrigation and temple management.

Answer: variyams

Q40. The Sanskrit root of 'dharma' is _____.

Answer: dhri

Q41. The four ashramas are brahmacharya, grihastha, vanaprastha and _____.

Answer: samnyasa

Q42. The sixteen rites of passage are called the shodasha _____.

Answer: samskaras

Q43. Sangam poetry on love is called _____ and on war and public life is called puram.

Answer: akam

Q44. The Milindapanho describes _____ stages of agricultural operations.

Answer: eight

Q45. The Nashik cave inscription of the _____ king Nahapana records donations deposited with guilds.

Answer: Shaka

C. True or False (1 mark each)

Q46. The Vedic texts existed in oral form for several centuries before being written down.

Answer: True.

Q47. The Rigveda mentions only one jana.

Answer: False. It mentions about thirty janas, five of which formed the panchajana.

Q48. Janapadas show a shift from kinship-based identity to territorial identity.

Answer: True.

Q49. The mahajanapadas arose between about 600 BCE and 300 CE.

Answer: True.

Q50. The Arthashastra says 'one wheel does not move the carriage', stressing cooperation in governance.

Answer: True.

Q51. The king in early India always ruled alone without any council.

Answer: False. He governed through a multi-layered administrative system including a council of ministers.

Q52. There are references to kings being elected or even expelled, so royal power was not always absolute.

Answer: True.

Q53. Early Vedic texts show a fixed social status strictly based on birth.

Answer: False. Occupations were flexible and mobile in the early stage.

Q54. There was no restriction on the number of jatis, while varnas were fixed at four.

Answer: True.

Q55. Several rulers like the Nandas, Mauryas and Guptas came from diverse social backgrounds.

Answer: True.

Q56. Village assemblies of the Chola empire depended on the government for patronage.

Answer: False. They functioned as independent, self-reliant institutions.

Q57. Dharma in this chapter means religion.

Answer: False. Dharma means duty, obligation, righteousness and moral conduct.

Q58. Women in the Vedic period took part in learning and some rituals.

Answer: True.

Q59. Bhakti means a path of direct connection with god, accessible to all irrespective of class or gender.

Answer: True.

Q60. Education in early India aimed only at career preparation.

Answer: False. It was holistic: values, skills, arts, yoga and service to the guru.

Q61. The Grand Anicut built by Karikala Chola remains in use today.

Answer: True.

Q62. Guilds also functioned as banks and trustees.

Answer: True.

Q63. India's trade with Rome expanded significantly by the early centuries CE.

Answer: True.

D. Match the Following (1 mark per pair)

Q64. Match the Veda with its description.

	Column A		Column B
1	Rigveda	A	Hymns arranged for musical recitation
2	Yajurveda	B	Prose explanations of ritual performances
3	Samaveda	C	Earliest veda, with 1,028 hymns
4	Atharvaveda	D	Hymns to ward off evil and treat ailments
5	Brahmana texts	E	Elaborates the performative aspects of yajnas

Answer: 1-C; 2-E; 3-A; 4-D; 5-B

Q65. Match the dynasty with its period/feature.

	Column A		Column B
1	Guptas	A	Rajaraja I and Brihadeeshwara Temple
2	Pallavas	B	About 320-550 CE
3	Chalukyas	C	Lasted nearly 500 years in the Deccan
4	Imperial Cholas	D	Brahmadeya villages
5	Satavahanas	E	Capital Badami; agraharams

Answer: 1-B; 2-D; 3-E; 4-A; 5-C

Q66. Match the term with its meaning.

	Column A		Column B
1	Gotra	A	Council of ministers
2	Endogamy	B	Guild
3	Variyam	C	Marrying within one's own group
4	Mantri-parishad	D	Village committee
5	Shreni	E	Patrilineal lineage traced to a Vedic sage

Answer: 1-E; 2-C; 3-D; 4-A; 5-B

Q67. Match the inscription with its feature.

	Column A		Column B
1	Junagadh Rock Inscription	A	Kudavolai system of village elections
2	Uttaramerur inscription	B	Guilds acting as banks
3	Nashik cave inscription	C	Records of Ashoka, Rudradaman I and Skandagupta
4	Mandsaur Stone Inscription	D	District office with five members
5	Damodarpur copper plates	E	Silk weavers' guild that migrated from Lata to Dashapura

Answer: 1-C; 2-A; 3-B; 4-E; 5-D

E. Assertion-Reason Questions (1 mark each)

Options: *(a) Both A and R are true and R is the correct explanation of A. (b) Both A and R are true but R is not the correct explanation of A. (c) A is true but R is false. (d) A is false but R is true.*

Q68. Assertion (A): The Vedas are regarded as foundational to Indian culture.
Reason (R): They are among the earliest texts and cultural practices have continued over time.

Answer: (a)

Q69. Assertion (A): Magadha became the most powerful mahajanapada.
Reason (R): It had a strategic location, fertile plains and strong rulers.

Answer: (a)

Q70. Assertion (A): The early Chola, Chera and Pandya kingdoms are the same as the later imperial ones.
Reason (R): Sangam poems describe them as the three crowned kings.

Answer: (d) A is false; R is true. The early kingdoms should not be confused with the imperial kingdoms that emerged many centuries later.

Q71. Assertion (A): Early Indian rulers had an awareness of the whole subcontinent as a political unit.
Reason (R): Terms like Jambudvipa, Bharatavarsha, Ashvamedha and chakravarti kshetra expressed authority over the subcontinent.

Answer: (a)

Q72. Assertion (A): Village assemblies in the Chola empire were important.
Reason (R): They managed revenue collection, irrigation, land management and settled disputes.

Answer: (a)

Q73. Assertion (A): Varna and jati were not always rigid.
Reason (R): Rulers came from diverse social backgrounds and there are instances of occupational mobility.

Answer: (a)

Q74. Assertion (A): Kings recorded the construction of dams and canals in inscriptions.
Reason (R): Agriculture depended on irrigation and was a major source of state revenue.

Answer: (a)

Q75. Assertion (A): Guilds were only associations of craftspersons.
Reason (R): The Nashik inscription shows guilds receiving deposits and paying interest.

Answer: (d) A is false; R is true. Guilds also worked as banking and credit institutions.

F. Short Answer Questions (2 to 3 marks each)

Q76. Define society and state.

Answer: A society is a system of social relationships among individuals sharing a common territory, culture and sense of belonging, regulated mainly by customs. A state is an organised political system based on rules and laws, with defined rights and duties of rulers and subjects and institutions to enforce law and order.

Q77. Name the four Vedas and mention one feature of each.

Answer: Rigveda: oldest, 1,028 hymns. Yajurveda: explains performative aspects of yajnas, includes prose. Samaveda: hymns arranged for musical recitation; basis of seven svaras. Atharvaveda: wide range of hymns, including for treating physical and mental ailments.

Q78. What are the four parts of each Veda?

Answer: Samhita (hymns), Brahmana (prose explanation of rituals), Aranyaka (philosophical speculations of forest sages) and Upanishad (on Atman and Brahman).

Q79. Who were the janas? Name the panchajana.

Answer: Janas were clans bound by kinship ties. The Yadu, Turvasha, Puru, Anu and Druhyu were collectively the panchajana ('five peoples').

Q80. Describe the three assemblies of the Vedic period.

Answer: Sabha: a smaller body of select elites with a judicial function. Samiti: a larger assembly on policy and political affairs, representing the broader population. Vidhata: a popular gathering of community members, a forum for discussions on warfare and other matters.

Q81. What archaeological evidence shows the change in the Ganga region in the first millennium BCE?

Answer: More settlements, iron implements, a wider variety of grains, PGW pottery, and later the glossy NBPW 'deluxe ware' in the middle Ganga region, showing a richer material culture.

Q82. What are janapadas and mahajanapadas?

Answer: Janapadas were territorial entities that developed from Vedic janas (about 1000-600 BCE). Mahajanapadas were bigger political units that rose between about 600 BCE and 300 CE; sixteen are usually mentioned.

Q83. Who were the three crowned kings of Tamilakam? What are their emblems?

Answer: The Cheras, Cholas and Pandyas (Vendar of Tamilakam). Emblems: bow for the Cheras, tiger for the Cholas and fish for the Pandyas.

Q84. What were the king's duties according to early texts?

Answer: To protect subjects from external threats and internal disorder, and to administer justice impartially. The Yajurveda coronation oath asks him to judge the strong and weak fairly and do good to the people.

Q85. What is the chakravarti kshetra?

Answer: In the Arthashastra, prithivi is equated with the chakravarti kshetra, the 'domain of a universal paramount ruler', the area between the Himalayas and the sea.

Q86. List Kautilya's seven constituents of the state (Saptanga).

Answer: King (swami), ministers (amatya), territory with population (janapada), forts (durga), treasury (kosha), army/law and order (danda) and allies (mitra).

Q87. What was the council of ministers?

Answer: The mantri-parishad was a small body of elder statesmen who advised and supported the king; it generally included the treasurer, chief tax collector, chief legal advisor and commander-in-chief. An Ashokan inscription shows it could take decisions in exceptional circumstances in the emperor's absence.

Q88. What is special about the Junagadh Rock Inscription?

Answer: It bears records of Ashoka (3rd century BCE, in Prakrit), Rudradaman I (c. 150 CE, in Sanskrit) and Skandagupta (5th century CE), spanning about 700 years; they refer to the Sudarshana Lake.

Q89. Describe the administrative divisions of early Indian kingdoms.

Answer: Kingdoms were divided into provinces (bhuktis in the north, mandalas in the south), then divisions (vishaya or bhoga; kottams or valanadu), districts (adhishthana or pattana; nadu), groups of villages (vithi; pattala, kurram) and villages as the lowest unit.

Q90. How was the Gupta administration different from earlier ones?

Answer: The Guptas retained much of the earlier system but introduced the sandhivigrahika (minister of peace and war), and amatyas evolved into kumaramatyas. The district office had five members: the head officer, chief banker, chief caravan trader, chief artisan and chief of revenue collection (Damodarpur plates).

Q91. What was special about Pallava administration?

Answer: Centralised monarchy with decentralised local governance; tax-free land grants to villages called Brahmadeya villages; village assemblies with variyams for irrigation, gardens and temples.

Q92. What was the Tripartite struggle?

Answer: A struggle among the Gurjara-Pratiharas, Palas and Rashtrakutas to control Kannauj, the capital of the Gurjara-Pratiharas in present-day Uttar Pradesh.

Q93. Describe the Kudavolai system.

Answer: From the Uttaramerur inscription of Parantaka I: names of eligible candidates were written on palm leaves and put in a pot; a young child drew leaves one by one in full public view, often at a temple, to select village assembly representatives, who were divided into variyams. Candidates needed 'honest earnings' and 'pure' minds.

Q94. What do samatva and rita mean?

Answer: Samatva is the principle of sameness: all bodies are made of the same matter and all consciousness is a manifestation of one supreme consciousness. Rita is the all-pervading cosmic order of harmony and balance in nature and society.

Q95. What is dharma?

Answer: Not religion, but duty, obligation, righteousness and moral conduct. The word comes from the root dhri, 'that which upholds'. In Buddhism the Pali equivalent is dhamma.

Q96. Differentiate between varna and jati.

Answer: Varna refers to four functional social categories (brahmana, kshatriya, vaishya, shudra), fixed at four. Jati is a social group that emerged through intermarriage, endogamy of migrating groups and territorial differences, and its number kept growing with new occupations.

Q97. Give evidence of social mobility in early India.

Answer: Rulers like the Nandas, Mauryas, Shungas, Satavahanas, Vakatakas and Guptas came from diverse backgrounds; the Mandsaur inscription (473 CE) records silk weavers' migration; the Karitalai plates record brahmanas as land managers; Rigveda 9.112.3 shows a family with different occupations.

Q98. What are the four ashramas and four purusharthas?

Answer: Ashramas: brahmacharya (student), grihastha (householder), vanaprastha (forest life) and samnyasa (renunciation). Purusharthas: dharma, artha, kama and moksha.

Q99. What was the role of women in the Vedic period?

Answer: Women took part in learning and some rituals, chariot races and the sabha. Hymns of the Rigveda are attributed to women sages like Apala, Vishvavara, Ghosha and Lopamudra. Goddesses like Usha and Aditi were revered.

Q100. Name some women mentioned in the chapter who contributed to society.

Answer: Prabhavati Gupta (regent of the Vakataka kingdom), Sangam poetesses Avvaiyar and Vennikuyattiyar, and the Chola royal woman Sembiyan Mahadevi (temple patron).

Q101. What was the Bhakti movement in the 6th century Tamil region?

Answer: A devotional path giving direct connection with god without elaborate rituals, open to all. The 12 Alvars praised Vishnu and the 63 Nayanmars praised Shiva in Tamil hymns.

Q102. Describe the gurukula system.

Answer: Students lived in the teacher's home, treated as members of the family, and followed a disciplined life. They studied the Vedas, grammar, logic, science, maths, medicine, astronomy, arts and martial arts, and practised yoga and service to the guru. The aim was holistic education grounded in dharma.

Q103. Name some ancient centres of learning.

Answer: Takshashila, Nalanda, Vikramashila, Vallabhi, Varanasi, Ujjayini, Kanchipuram, Odantapuri, Jagaddala, among others.

Q104. What were the main sources of revenue and farming under the Mauryas?

Answer: Land tax was usually one-sixth of the produce; land was classified for revenue; the state cleared forests but protected some; crops included rice, pulses, wheat, linseed, mustard, saffron, sugarcane, vegetables and fruits.

Q105. What does the Junagadh inscription of Rudradaman say about irrigation?

Answer: It records that Pushyagupta, a governor of Chandragupta Maurya, built a dam on Sudarshana Lake near Girnar, showing the state's active role in irrigation.

Q106. What were guilds? What functions did they perform?

Answer: Shrenis were associations of people in the same profession. They expanded trade, regulated quality and fixed prices, supervised members through guild courts, and acted as banks, financiers and trustees. The Jataka mentions eighteen types.

G. Long Answer Questions (5 marks each)

Q107. How did political organisation change from the Vedic period to the age of large empires?

Answer: 1. **Vedic period:** society was organised in kin-based janas led by a rajan (clan chief), with assemblies (sabha, samiti, vidhata).
2. **Janapadas (about 1000-600 BCE):** from kinship identity to territorial identity.
3. **Mahajanapadas (about 600 BCE-300 CE):** sixteen bigger units, including monarchies (rajyas) and republics (ganas or sanghas). Magadha rose due to location, fertile plains and strong rulers.
4. **Empires:** Mauryas (from 321 BCE), then Shungas (185 BCE), Satavahanas (Deccan), Kushanas, Guptas (about 320-550 CE), and in the south the Cholas.
5. **Regional powers:** Pallavas, Chalukyas, Pratiharas, Palas, Rashtrakutas.
There was also continuity: the ideal of a pan-Indian monarch (ashvamedha, chakravarti samrat) and dharma.

Q108. Describe the role of the king, important officers and the methods used to govern large territories.

Answer: King: protected subjects from external threats and internal disorder, and gave justice. The Arthashastra says officers follow an active king; the Yajurveda oath asks for impartiality. Kingship was generally hereditary, but kings could be elected or expelled.
Officers: council of ministers (treasurer, tax collector, legal advisor, commander-in-chief); Gupta mantri, kumaramatyas and sandhivigrahika; district pradeshikas; gramika (village headman); city governors.
Methods: division into provinces, divisions, districts and villages; consultation with bankers, caravan leaders, artisans and scribes; decentralisation of power (300-800 CE); autonomous village assemblies handling local affairs.

Q109. What do the Rigveda, Arthashastra and Mahabharata reveal about political and social life?

Answer: Rigveda: clans (janas), the rajan as clan chief, the assemblies, occupational diversity (verse 9.112.3), the Purushasukta on four varnas, women sages, worship of nature deities.
Arthashastra: detailed administration, the Saptanga theory of the state, the council of ministers, land revenue and trade regulation, and the idea of the chakravarti kshetra.
Mahabharata (Shanti Parva): ethical conduct, justice and a king's duties to his subjects; characters of all varnas uphold samatva; the epic critiques discrimination; Bhishma defines dharma as that which upholds beings.

Q110. Explain the village administration under the Cholas and the importance of village assemblies.

Answer: The Chola empire was divided into mandalams, valanadus, nadus and Urs (villages), the smallest unit. Village councils settled disputes and managed local affairs including revenue collection, land management, irrigation, road construction and record keeping. They were independent, self-reliant institutions not dependent on government patronage.
The Uttaramerur inscription of Parantaka I (10th century CE) describes the Kudavolai system: names of eligible candidates on palm leaves in a pot, drawn by a child in public. Elected members formed variyams (committees) for irrigation (tank), justice and taxes. Candidates had to have honest earnings and a pure mind. Village assemblies also existed under the Pallavas, Chalukyas, Palas and Pratiharas.

Q111. Describe the varna and jati system and social mobility in early India.

Answer: Early Vedic texts do not show a fixed status by birth; identity depended on ethnicity, region, village, gotra, language and especially occupation, which was flexible (Rigveda 9.112.3). The Purushasukta first mentions four varnas: brahmanas (study, teach, yajnas, dana), rajanyas/kshatriyas (warfare, protection, justice), vaishyas (agriculture, pastoralism, trade) and shudras (assist others, but also farming, crafts and trade). Varna was functional; the Sutta Nipata says one is a brahmana by deeds, not birth.

Over time jatis emerged through intermarriage, endogamy and territorial differences; their number was unlimited.

Mobility: rulers from diverse backgrounds (Nandas, Mauryas, Guptas, etc.), silk weavers' guild (Mandsaur), brahmanas as land managers (Karitalai), and occupation-based society in Sangam texts (Tolkappiyam, Pattinappalai).

Q112. Explain the family and social life in early India: ashramas, purusharthas and the role of women.

Answer: Family: the kula was the smallest unit; villages (grama) formed a visha under a vishapati; above it was the jana with the raja. Gotra was a patrilineal lineage tracing to a rishi and regulated marriage.

Ashramas: brahmacharya, grihastha, vanaprastha and samnyasa, with sixteen samskaras marking life stages.

Purusharthas: dharma, artha, kama and moksha; wealth should be guided by dharma.

Women: in the Vedic period they were learned, took part in rituals and assemblies; women sages like Apala and Lopamudra composed hymns. Later their roles fluctuated, but queens like Prabhavati Gupta and Sembiyan Mahadevi, and Sangam women in farming, crafts and poetry (Avvaiyar), show their contribution.

Q113. Explain ethical ideas and religious life in early India including the emergence of Bhakti.

Answer: Ethics: samatva (sameness of all beings), rita (cosmic order) and dharma (duty and righteousness) guided state and society. Ashoka's edicts promoted dhamma (non-violence, compassion, respect in the family); the Uttaramerur inscription demanded honest earnings from candidates; Kamandaka's Nitisara and Banabhatta's Kadambari reflect on ethics in governance.

Religion: Vedic deities were associated with nature and invoked with yajnas; practices like sun worship continue in Chhath and Makar Sankranti. Around the mid first millennium BCE, renunciants (parivrajaka, bhikshu, shramana) such as Buddha and Mahavira emerged. Worship later centred on Vishnu, Shiva and Shakti. Bhakti became prominent in the 6th century Tamil region through the Alvars and Nayanmars.

Q114. Describe education and knowledge traditions of early India.

Answer: Education was holistic. It cultivated truth, patience, humility, self-control and reverence for all beings, and trained pupils to live by dharma. Students studied the Vedas, grammar, logic, philosophy, ethics, mathematics, science, medicine and astronomy, plus music, dance, painting, archery, yoga and meditation. The guru-shishya relationship was sacred, and in the gurukula the student was like a family member.

Higher learning centres included Takshashila, Nalanda (established 427 CE), Vallabhi (480 CE) and Vikramashila, attracting students from many regions.

Literary heritage: Panini's Ashtadhyayi, Manu-smriti, Charakasamhita, Sushrutasamhita, Kalidasa's works, the Tirukkural, Silappadikaram and Manimekalai.

Q115. Describe the economy of early India: agriculture, irrigation, trade and guilds.

Answer: Agriculture: the backbone of the economy. The Mauryan state regulated villages, classified land and levied about one-sixth of the produce. Crops included rice, pulses, wheat, mustard and sugarcane; Deccan black soil supported cotton.
Irrigation: reservoirs, canals and dams, e.g. the dam on Sudarshana Lake (Junagadh inscription) and the Grand Anicut of Karikala Chola, still in use.
Trade: Dakshinapatha and Uttarapatha routes, ports like Muziris, Kaveripattinam, Arikamedu and Masulipatnam, expanding trade with Rome.
Guilds (shrenis): regulated quality and prices, had their own courts and worked as banks (Nashik inscription), and organised textile production (e.g. silk weavers, ivory workers of Vidisha at Sanchi). Silver punch-marked coins circulated.

Q116. Explain how ideas of dharma and the chakravarti samrat created unity across the subcontinent.

Answer: Early Indian monarchs had an awareness of the whole subcontinent expressed through terms like Jambudvipa, Bharatavarsha, Prithivi and chakravarti kshetra, and through rituals such as the Ashvamedha and Rajasuya. Ashoka spoke of change in the spiritual life of Jambudvipa; the Arthashastra defined prithivi as the area between the Himavat and the sea. The Sangam Chera king Nedunjeral Adan extended conquests to the Himalayas, and the Chola Rajendra I took the title Gangaikonda in the 11th century.
Dharma, the shared socio-ethical principle, guided rulers and subjects alike from the Mauryas to the Cholas. Together they promoted common values, governance and the idea of the Indian subcontinent as one political and cultural entity.